

MOTHERHOOD AND marriage

MESOAMERICAN SOCIETY

In the ancient societies of Central America and Mexico—known as Mesoamerica—the value of women was associated with their role as mothers. However, while women generally occupied a subservient role to men, they performed vital functions in society. This reality was reflected in the pantheon of Mesoamerican deities, which included beings such as the jaguar goddess Ix Chel, who was associated with childbirth, medicine, and weaving, and had the power to raise storms and floods. In Mesoamerican societies, everyday tasks were imbued with spiritual significance. For example, spinning and weaving, carried out by women using a back-strap loom, were seen as ritual reenactments of creation.

Mesoamericans believed that motherhood granted women divine favor.

Those women who died in childbirth were believed to ascend directly to the heavens, and Mesoamericans saw the physical effort (including the risk of death) involved in childbirth as analogous to the dangers of warfare experienced by men. Their reverence of creation and motherhood even extended to women's appearances. While both sexes had tattoos, it was also common for women to decorate their faces and bodies with red

paint, a color that the Mesoamericans associated with the east, the rising sun, and rebirth.

Living and loving

In most civilizations, such as the Olmec and Maya—which flourished in the region from around 1200 BCE—men usually worked in the fields and hunted, while women

focused on tending kitchen gardens, foraging, and preparing food. Some women also made pottery, or worked as healers or midwives. Mesoamerican rulers were nearly always male, but women could wield political power as widows or consorts of leaders, or as regents for underage sons. Lady K'Abel even became *kaloomté* (supreme warrior) of the Wak Kingdom (in modern-day northern Guatemala) after marrying its king in 672, and this title gave her higher authority than him.

While it was rare for a woman to rule in her own right, there were a few examples—such as the formidable Lady Six Sky, who ruled the city-state of Naranjo (present-day Guatemala) from 682–741 CE, fighting off many enemy attacks, and acting as regent for her son until he came of age. Monuments commissioned by the queen show her standing triumphantly over prisoners of war—an unusual depiction for a woman at the time.

Archaeological evidence suggests the extremes to which Mesoamericans went to alter their physical appearance. Carvings and sculptures show that for both men and women, the most desirable physical features were a long nose, being crosseyed, and a sloping forehead. The first was achieved by wearing

3 in 4
people in the
Mesoamerican
world worked
in agriculture,
which revolved
around corn.

◀ Goddess of childbirth

Ix Chel, the jaguar goddess, was a powerful figure in Mayan folklore. The goddess, depicted as an ugly old woman, presided over the sweat bath, where women often gave birth.

